MSC MARRIAGE AND FAMILY THERAPY

PROGRAMME DOCUMENT · LECTURE LIBRARY

PD 00

Programme document

Programme Handbook

PROGRAMME

For students and lecturers · read before the semester

One of four programme documents that frame the 28-volume lecture library: the student handbook, the lecturer's teaching and assessment guide, the figure index and the visual figure gallery.

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Programme Handbook — MSc Marriage and Family Therapy

This volume is one of 28 course books that together cover the whole MSc Marriage and Family Therapy taught programme. Each book is written to carry a 14–16 week semester on its own: every week pairs a core idea with the practice that follows from it, a worked case, and a reflective task, and each book closes with an integration chapter, a glossary and a self-assessment paper with model answers.

The books are designed to be read straight through before the semester begins, revisited week by week, and used again in revision. Cross-references point to the other volumes where a topic is treated in more depth.

How to cite this volume

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A note on the case material

All families, couples and individuals in this book are fictional composites. They are written to teach pattern recognition, not to describe any real person. Nothing here replaces supervised clinical practice, professional registration, legal advice or medical care; legal content is orientation only and must be checked against the law of the relevant jurisdiction.

The lecture library

Twenty-eight self-contained course books carry the taught programme: eight in Semester One, seven in Semester Two, seven in Semester Three including the thesis, and six electives. The volume you are holding is marked in the margin.

Code	Course	Semester	Units
MFT 701	Fundamentals of Marriage and Family Therapy	One	1.71
MFT 702	Theories of Family Therapy	One	1.71
MFT 703	Human Development Across the Lifespan	One	1.71
MFT 704	Ethical and Legal Issues in Therapy	One	1.71
MFT 705	Research Methods in Marriage and Family Therapy	One	1.71
MFT 706	Clinical Practice and Techniques	One	1.71
MFT 707	Assessment and Diagnosis in Family Therapy	One	1.71
MFT 708	Cultural Competence in Therapy	One	1.71
MFT 709	Group Therapy Techniques	Two	1.71
MFT 710	Couples Therapy	Two	1.71
MFT 711	Child and Adolescent Therapy	Two	1.71
MFT 712	Crisis Intervention Strategies	Two	1.71
MFT 713	Substance Abuse and Family Dynamics	Two	1.71
MFT 714	Trauma-Informed Care	Two	1.71
MFT 715	Family Systems Theory	Two	1.71
MFT 716	Communication Skills in Therapy	Three	1.71
MFT 717	Psychopathology in Families	Three	1.71
MFT 718	Intimacy and Relationship Dynamics	Three	1.71
MFT 719	Family Life Cycle and Transitions	Three	1.71
MFT 720	Supervision and Consultation in Therapy	Three	1.71
MFT 721	Research Methodology	Three	1.71
MFT 722	Professional Development and Self-Care	Electives	1.71
MFT 723	Special Populations in Therapy	Electives	1.71
MFT 724	Family Law and Advocacy	Electives	1.71
MFT 725	Integrative Approaches in Therapy	Electives	1.71
MFT 726	Neurobiology of Relationships	Electives	1.71
MFT 727	Play Therapy Techniques	Electives	1.71
MFT 770	Master Thesis	Three	1.71

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> **MASTER OF SCIENCE (MSC) IN MARRIAGE AND FAMILY THERAPY**
> · 27 taught courses + thesis · 3 semesters · Complete lecture library

1. What this programme is

This is a **professional, clinical, systemic** master's programme. It trains graduates to work with couples, families, children and organisations as relationships rather than as collections of individuals. The programme therefore differs from a clinical psychology or counselling degree in three specific ways:

1. **The unit of treatment is the relationship.** You will learn to assess and intervene in patterns between people — cycles, triangles, coalitions, boundaries — not only in the inner world of one person.
2. **The therapist is part of the system.** From Week 1 you will be trained to notice your own effect on the room: your reactivity, your culture, your family-of-origin triggers, your use of power.
3. **Practice is relational and accountable.** Supervision, ethics, law, and cultural humility are not add-on courses; they are the conditions under which the clinical work is allowed to happen.

The programme is designed for a **14–16 week semester** at roughly 1.71 units per course. In practice, that means about **3 contact hours per week** per course (a 2-hour lecture plus a 1-hour practical, skills lab, or supervision seminar), plus 4–6 hours of reading and practice between sessions.

2. Programme structure at a glance

Semester One — Foundations

Code	Course title	Units	Focus
MFT 701	Fundamentals of Marriage and Family Therapy	1.71	What MFT is; history; systemic epistemology; the profession
MFT 702	Theories of Family Therapy	1.71	The major schools, compared and critiqued
MFT 703	Human Development Across the Lifespan	1.71	Development from infancy to later life, in family context
MFT 704	Ethical and Legal Issues in Therapy	1.71	Codes, law, confidentiality, risk, dual relationships
MFT 705	Research Methods in Marriage and Family Therapy	1.71	Designs, measurement, appraisal, ethics of research
MFT 706	Clinical Practice and Techniques	1.71	Joining, questioning, enactment, structuring, homework

Code	Course title	Units	Focus
MFT 707	Assessment and Diagnosis in Family Therapy	1.71	Multi-informant assessment, formulation, DSM/ICD use
MFT 708	Cultural Competence in Therapy	1.71	Culture, power, race, faith, class, language

Semester Two — Application

Code	Course title	Units	Focus
MFT 709	Group Therapy Techniques	1.71	Group process, stages, facilitation, co-therapy
MFT 710	Couples Therapy	1.71	Couple assessment, EFT, Gottman, infidelity, divorce
MFT 711	Child and Adolescent Therapy	1.71	Developmental assessment, family-based child work
MFT 712	Crisis Intervention Strategies	1.71	Suicide, violence, disaster, acute family crisis
MFT 713	Substance Abuse and Family Dynamics	1.71	Addiction as a family-organising process; recovery
MFT 714	Trauma-Informed Care	1.71	Trauma physiology, phased treatment, re-traumatisation
MFT 715	Family Systems Theory	1.71	Cybernetics, structure, communication, narrative systems

Semester Three — Integration and Inquiry

Code	Course title	Units	Focus
MFT 716	Communication Skills in Therapy	1.71	Micro-skills, difficult conversations, repair
MFT 717	Psychopathology in Families	1.71	Severe mental distress in relational context
MFT 718	Intimacy and Relationship Dynamics	1.71	Attachment, sexuality, desire, betrayal, repair
MFT 719	Family Life Cycle and Transitions	1.71	Stage transitions, migration, loss, blended families
MFT 720	Supervision and Consultation in Therapy	1.71	Supervision models, feedback, parallel process
MFT 721	Research Methodology	1.71	Advanced design, analysis, thesis preparation
MFT 770	Master Thesis	1.71	Supervised original research

Electives (choose according to track)

Code	Course title	Units
MFT 722	Professional Development and Self-Care	1.71
MFT 723	Special Populations in Therapy	1.71
MFT 724	Family Law and Advocacy	1.71
MFT 725	Integrative Approaches in Therapy	1.71
MFT 726	Neurobiology of Relationships	1.71
MFT 727	Play Therapy Techniques	1.71

File map

Code	File
MFT 701	01-semester-one/MFT-701-fundamentals-of-marriage-and-family-therapy.md
MFT 702	01-semester-one/MFT-702-theories-of-family-therapy.md
MFT 703	01-semester-one/MFT-703-human-development-across-the-lifespan.md
MFT 704	01-semester-one/MFT-704-ethical-and-legal-issues-in-therapy.md
MFT 705	01-semester-one/MFT-705-research-methods-in-mft.md
MFT 706	01-semester-one/MFT-706-clinical-practice-and-techniques.md
MFT 707	01-semester-one/MFT-707-assessment-and-diagnosis-in-family-therapy.md
MFT 708	01-semester-one/MFT-708-cultural-competence-in-therapy.md
MFT 709	02-semester-two/MFT-709-group-therapy-techniques.md
MFT 710	02-semester-two/MFT-710-couples-therapy.md
MFT 711	02-semester-two/MFT-711-child-and-adolescent-therapy.md
MFT 712	02-semester-two/MFT-712-crisis-intervention-strategies.md
MFT 713	02-semester-two/MFT-713-substance-abuse-and-family-dynamics.md
MFT 714	02-semester-two/MFT-714-trauma-informed-care.md
MFT 715	02-semester-two/MFT-715-family-systems-theory.md
MFT 716	03-semester-three/MFT-716-communication-skills-in-therapy.md
MFT 717	03-semester-three/MFT-717-psychopathology-in-families.md
MFT 718	03-semester-three/MFT-718-intimacy-and-relationship-dynamics.md
MFT 719	03-semester-three/MFT-719-family-life-cycle-and-transitions.md
MFT 720	03-semester-three/MFT-720-supervision-and-consultation.md
MFT 721	03-semester-three/MFT-721-research-methodology.md
MFT 770	03-semester-three/MFT-770-master-thesis.md
MFT 722	04-electives/MFT-722-professional-development-and-self-care.md

Code	File
MFT 723	`04-electives/MFT-723-special-populations-in-therapy.md`
MFT 724	`04-electives/MFT-724-family-law-and-advocacy.md`
MFT 725	`04-electives/MFT-725-integrative-approaches-in-therapy.md`
MFT 726	`04-electives/MFT-726-neurobiology-of-relationships.md`
MFT 727	`04-electives/MFT-727-play-therapy-techniques.md`

3. Graduate competencies

By the end of the programme a graduate should be able to do the following **unaided, under supervision**:

#	Competency	Where it is built
1	Conduct a systemic assessment, including genogram, interaction observation and risk screen	701, 706, 707, 719
2	Formulate a relational hypothesis and share it with a family in plain language	701, 707, 715
3	Select and justify a treatment model, and integrate two models coherently	702, 715, 725
4	Use core clinical micro-skills: joining, enactment, circular questioning, reframing, structuring	706, 716
5	Work with couples, children, adolescents, groups and families with severe distress	709, 710, 711, 717
6	Assess and manage risk: suicide, self-harm, violence, abuse, safeguarding	704, 712, 714
7	Practise ethically, legally and with cultural humility, including documentation	704, 708, 724
8	Use and critique research evidence; design and complete an original study	705, 721, 770
9	Give and receive clinical supervision; use consultation effectively	720
10	Sustain a reflective, self-caring professional practice	722

4. Regulation-style essentials

4.1 Attendance and participation

Skills labs and supervision seminars cannot be made up by reading. A minimum of **75% attendance** in practical sessions is normally required before a student may sit the clinical examination. Absence from a session in which a student would have role-played a client must be made up, because peers depend on one another to practise.

4.2 Assessment pattern (per course)

Component	Weight	Notes
Continuous assessment: weekly practical/reflective log	20%	Submitted fortnightly; not graded on insight but on consistency and specificity
Case formulation or applied assignment	30%	2,000–2,500 words, anonymised, with supervisor sign-off
End-of-semester written examination	50%	Two hours; seen-case + essay + short answers

The **Master Thesis (MFT 770)** is assessed separately: proposal (10%), ethics approval (pass/fail gate), thesis (70%), oral defence (20%).

4.3 Clinical placement

Most programmes require **300–500 supervised client contact hours** across Semesters Two and Three, including a minimum of 100 relational (couple/family) hours. Log every session: date, modality, hours, presenting issue, risk screen completed (Y/N), supervision received. This log is a professional document — treat it as you would a clinical record.

4.4 Supervision requirement

A minimum ratio of **1 hour of supervision to 5 hours of client contact** is the working norm, with at least one live or recorded observation per month. Students may not carry relational cases without a named supervisor.

4.5 Academic integrity and case material

Every case written for assessment must be **disguised**: change names, ages by a year or two, occupations, locations, family composition and any identifying detail. Never submit material that a reader could trace to a real family. Fabricating a case is a more serious offence than writing a weak one — write about a composite or a role-play if you have no suitable live case.

4.6 Fitness to practise

Clinical programmes carry a fitness-to-practise obligation. Persistent boundary problems, dishonesty in records, untreated impairment, or unsafe practice in role-play are addressed through a support-and- remediation process, not only through marks. Asking for help early is treated as professional behaviour, not weakness.

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5. How the books fit together

The curriculum spirals rather than stacks. The same case — the Adeyemi family, used in several books — is visited repeatedly at increasing depth:

Book	What you do with the Adeyemi family
701	Map the system; identify the referral question
702	Apply three different schools to the same family

Book	What you do with the Adeyemi family
706	Practise joining and circular questioning in role-play
707	Complete a multi-informant assessment and 5-P formulation
710	Work the couple's pursue–withdraw cycle
711	Meet Amara individually without losing the system
715	Redraw the structure and communication patterns
717	Consider differential diagnosis and medication interface
719	Locate the family at a stage transition and plan for the next

Using one family across courses is deliberate: it teaches you that **models are lenses, not truths**, and that a real family does not arrive labelled with a theory.

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6. Reading strategy

Three tiers of reading are marked in each book:

- **Core (must read before the session).** Roughly 20–30 pages per week.
- **Applied (read one).** A case study, manual chapter or paper that shows the model in action.
- **Critical (read before the assignment).** A critique, meta-analysis or culturally situated paper.

If you are behind, read the core tier and the week's practical, and borrow notes for the rest. Do not skip the practicals; they are where the learning is consolidated.

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7. The library, at a glance

- **28 volumes** (27 courses + thesis), each 14–16 weeks.
- **40 original figures**, indexed in `02-figure-index.md`.
- **One teaching and assessment guide** for lecturers: `01-teaching-and-assessment-guide.md`.
- A built HTML edition with sidebar navigation, search, and print styles: `python3 scripts/build_site.py --serve`.
- **A print edition**: each course exists as a finished A4 PDF with cover, contents and page numbers in `../pdf/`, and the whole programme is bound into `MFT-Library-Complete-28-volumes.pdf` (449 pages). Print the week you are teaching, or the whole book at the start of the semester.

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8. A closing word to the student

You are training to sit with people at the worst moments of their lives — a disclosure of betrayal, a child who will not speak, a family deciding whether to stay together, a death that has just happened. Technique matters, and this programme will give you plenty. But the thing that will make you safe and useful is simpler: the capacity to stay calm, curious and kind while another person's distress is in the room, and to know honestly what you do not know.

That capacity is built slowly, in supervision, in your own therapy, in your family, and in the ordinary discipline of showing up. Start now.